More Than Just Numbers

Mrinalini Srinivasan believes in the value of long tenures, cross-functional learning and staying open to new ideas

BY **KRISHNA GOPALAN**



PHOTO BY **MILIND SHELTE**

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MRINALINI SRINIVASAN

CFO & Whole-time Director, Castrol India

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ONE OF THE things that stands out when one speaks to Mrinalini Srinivasan is her belief in a long-tenured career. She joined Castrol last year in July after a 17-year stint with Procter & Gamble, with the last position being CFO for the hygiene and health business. The need to spend time in an organisation may have come from her father. "He worked with L&T for 40 years," she says.

Srinivasan, who is Castrol India's CFO and Whole-time Director, gently says her current employer has been in the country for 115 years. She joined P&G right after picking up an MBA from FMS, Delhi in 2008. In fact, she went there for a three-month internship in the midst of B-school, before eventually joining them.

Perhaps making the shift from one FMCG company to another was easy. Srinivasan agrees with that. By way of background, she spent a good part of her early years in Indore (first at Daly College and then a degree in electronics and instrumentation engineering), where her mother was a teacher. "I was very active in school and participated in swimming and debating among other things. The objective was to be multi-skilled and that has helped in my career," she thinks. Srinivasan says she has "never been scared of trying".

Castrol has an industrial (B2B piece) that enhances her job profile and services too, which she quietly says is exciting. "There's a lot of learning for me and I get to do multiple things," is her view.

Srinivasan likes interacting with people and is stimulated by a great conversation. We are speaking to her in the middle of a long war and Castrol has kept an eagle eye on oil prices. "This has to be the most disruptive phase for Castrol India," says Srinivasan. A lot of innovative thinking is more than welcome now. "No idea is bad regardless of where it comes from," is her view. It's hard to counter that. BT

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NOTE *The rank is based on* BT*'s proprietary methodology involving profit after tax, profit growth, and operating profit margin, focusing on profitability as the key metric to judge performance*